

CORY AND THE COMPLAINT BOX

(a short story by Lucinda Rollings)

Expressive Reading – Manamo’ui Lovodua

Cory dashed through the front door and dropped his books inside. “Be there in a minute,” he yelled to Jake. Cory grabbed his ball glove and headed for the field next door.

A little while later: “Cory, come here! Cory – *right now!*” Cory pretended not to hear his stepdad and kept on playing. Soon, Dad Bradley was in his face, hands on hips, glaring, “Corbin Edward Douglass! Get into the house this minute.” Cory threw down his glove and marched in front of Dad Bradley, mumbling all the way.

The scene at home was not pleasant. “You’re not my dad and you can’t tell me what to do,” Cory yelled. “And you’re not perfect, either. I hear Mom complaining about you tracking mud through the house, so leave me alone.” Cory stomped off to his room and slammed the door.

After a half hour of tears, tears that Cory tried very hard to hold back, Cory got on his knees. “Dear God,” he prayed, “I’ve tried very hard to like Dad Bradley. Mom is so much happier now that he is around. But...but we just can’t seem to get along. He yells. I yell. No matter what I do, I just can’t please him. I don’t know what to do!”

Tap-tap-tap. “Go away,” Cory grumbled.

“It’s me,” Mom answered, quietly opening the door. Dad Bradley peered at him from behind her.

“I’m sorry for being so hot-headed, Cory,” Dad Bradley began. Cory stuffed his pillow over his head, hoping not to hear. “When I saw your books scattered all over the floor again, well, after a

day of cleaning up after the bricklayers, it was the last straw. Will you forgive me?"

Cory pulled the pillow tighter. Finally, Mom broke the silence.

"I have an idea. Let's make a complaint box for each of us. Each time one of us does something someone else doesn't like, instead of yelling at each other, we'll write it down and put it in that person's complaint box. At the end of the week, we'll sit down calmly, read through all the things in our boxes and discuss what we can do to improve."

"Sounds good to me," Dad Bradley agreed.

Cory peeked out from under his pillow. "Okay," he muttered.

Several times each day for the next week, Cory scribbled in big, bold letters on little pieces of paper, then he stuffed them into Dad Bradley's box. On Sunday afternoon, Mom brought the boxes into the living room. "Let's see how we did this week," she said. Cory smirked.

"I'll open mine first," Dad Bradley offered. He pulled out slip after slip; then he read, "Wet towels on the shower floor.' Sorry Angie. 'Leaving the top off the jelly jar.' Sorry again. 'Parking in the middle on the driveway so I can't play basketball.' That one must be from Cory," Dad Bradley commented. "I'll try to do better."

He continued, " 'Not letting me stay up until 10pm'. 'Making me do homework before I play ball.' 'Not letting me go fishing with Jake.' 'Yelling at me in front of my friends.' 'Not letting me watch...'"

The slips went on and on. Cory sneezed as Dad Bradley read his failures for all to hear.

"I'll open my box next," Mom offered with a sigh. Cory had been so stuck on Dad Bradley's faults

that he hadn't even thought about Mom's. She had one slip inside.

" 'I love you,'" she read. Dad Bradley smiled at her but Mum's eyes fell to the floor. "I love you too, Brad. But I know I'm not perfect."

"None of us is," Dad Bradley replied, pointing to his pile, "especially me. But I found a verse in the Bible that says love covers a multitude of sins. When we really love someone, we forgive their faults. And from now on, with God's help, that's what I'm going to try to do."

Cory remembered another passage of Scripture he had learned at Bible club – the love chapter, 1 Corinthians 13. Love is patient. Love is kind. Love is not easily angered. Love keeps no record of wrong.

"There sure isn't any love between me and you", Cory thought, glaring at Dad Bradley.

"Okay, Cory. It's your turn," Mom said.

Cory shook his box. "Feels like a lot in here," he commented.

"None of us is perfect," Mom repeated.

Cory opened the box and counted. One...two...three...27 slips. He unfolded the first one and silently read. He read the second one. He read the third one. Each time, he glanced up at Dad Bradley. By the 27th slip, tears were streaming down his cheeks and he was hugging Dad Bradley fiercely. Mom looked at the slips.

Each one said, "I love you" written on it.

"I promise I'll try to do better," Dad Bradley mumbled, wiping his damp cheeks on his shirt sleeve.

"Me, too," came Cory's muffled reply.

